

Chapter 159-1

Gilded light and shadows overlapped and fell on the ground, falling into the crowd of people coming and going.

Xu Qingzhu sat on a bench in the hospital, holding the examination report, staring blankly.

She was pregnant.

Already over forty days along.

Coming to the hospital for a checkup had been a difficult decision. Xu Qingzhu had thought about it all afternoon in her office before making an appointment with this doctor.

She had deliberately avoided Zhao Xuning and also avoided Lin Luoxi.

The unfinished half of her sentence had eventually been slowly revealed under Lin Luoxi's curious gaze, shaking her head to deny Lin Luoxi's guess.

Yet she had anxiously made an appointment with a doctor for a checkup.

At the time, she had thought it was her period, but it turned out she had nearly had a miscarriage.

When she stopped bleeding afterward, she had thought it was because of too much stress causing her menstrual cycle to be irregular.

She hadn't thought to come to the hospital to get checked, and the result...

Counting the days, it should have been around when Liang Shi had just returned.

After Liang Shi temporarily marked her, both of their pheromones were very strong, so they had become intertwined in the confined space.

That was how it had happened.

This child seemed to have come at a very inconvenient time.

It was when their passion was at its peak, and there had been no plans for pregnancy, so they had gone wild in bed—and nearly caused a miscarriage.

...

The doctor said if she had come even one day later, the child wouldn't be in this condition anymore.

So now she had to rest and focus on protecting the pregnancy.

Xu Qingzhu sat there in a daze for a long time, until the setting sun sank and hid behind the mountains, the moon hung high, and all the lights in the city lit up in an instant, making this dim world bright.

Then she heard a nurse calling her name. "Xu Qingzhu."

Only then did Xu Qingzhu come back to her senses. She followed the nurse into the hospital room. The doctor first inserted a needle into Xu Qingzhu's wrist for an IV drip, then stood there giving instructions: "During this time, avoid spicy and greasy foods. Your morning sickness is quite severe, so try not to eat seafood—don't even smell fish or shrimp. But you need to keep up your nutrition. Drink some porridge every day—red dates and goji berries are best."

"Oh, right." The doctor suddenly asked. "Where's your partner?"

Xu Qingzhu was startled: "She's busy."

The doctor frowned: "You two were really too careless. The child almost didn't make it."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together: "Sorry."

"Why are you apologizing to me?" The doctor had a hint of exasperation in her tone.¹ "The one you really owe an apology to is the child. You need to be very careful from now on, or there's a risk of miscarriage at any time."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "I understand."

Seeing her being so well-behaved with a guilty expression on her face, the doctor didn't have the heart to say more. She comforted her with a few words: "But don't worry. Medical care in our country is very advanced now. We'll give you a few more injections of specialized medicine and you'll be fine. But remember what I said earlier. Also, remember this—absolutely no intercourse for three months."

"Mm-hmm." Xu Qingzhu agreed to everything.

The doctor stared at her but still couldn't help nagging: "During pregnancy, having a partner's companionship is definitely best, both for the mother and for the child. No matter how busy your partner is, she needs to make time to be with you. And your mood is clearly not good right now—your emotions have been fluctuating a lot recently. Try to maintain a happy state every day from now on."

"Okay." Xu Qingzhu said.

After instructing the nurse to cover her with a blanket, the doctor left. Xu Qingzhu gently closed her eyes, suddenly feeling drowsy. Before she could think much more, she drifted off to sleep.

1. The Chinese phrase "恨铁不成钢" (hèn tiě bù chéng gāng) literally means "to hate iron for not becoming steel." It describes the frustration felt when someone you care about fails to live up to their potential or makes careless mistakes. It's often used by elders or authority figures expressing exasperation mixed with concern. ←

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That evening, at Lin Luoxi's home.

Lin Luoxi sat in the living room holding her phone, chatting with a friend. "I have a friend who hasn't had much appetite lately. She feels like throwing up whenever she smells fish. What's going on?"

The other party was startled: "Has she been sexually active? Has she had her period recently?"

Lin Luoxi said: "She is married. As for her sex life... I'm not sure. Her period... I'm not sure about that either."

"Isn't this friend just you? You don't even know when your own period is?" Her friend said bluntly. "And when did you get married? How come I didn't know? Xixi, that's not cool of you."

Lin Luoxi: "..."

"It's not me." Lin Luoxi said. "It really is a friend of mine."

Friend: "?"

"I suspect it's pregnancy." Lin Luoxi said. "What do you think?"

"Go get it checked." Her friend said. "There's a 60% chance it's pregnancy. If she's been sexually active and hasn't had her period for over a month, then there's an 80% chance."

Lin Luoxi paused upon hearing this: "Alright then."

This friend of hers was a doctor, which was why Lin Luoxi had called to ask her.

After she hung up, Sally came over. "Pregnant? Baby, you're pregnant?"

Lin Luoxi: "..."

Did this person have some kind of selective hearing skill?

"Baby." Sally looked excited. "Are we going to have our own little one?"

Lin Luoxi looked at her coldly: "We do it three times a week. Do you think if there was a little one, she'd still be alive?"

Sally: "..."

Sally's smile gradually froze on her face, momentarily unsure how to react.

Lin Luoxi continued looking down at her phone, searching for related information, completely calm.

Unexpectedly, after a moment, Sally said seriously: "Baby, let's do it less from now on."

Lin Luoxi: "?"

Lin Luoxi got up and walked toward the bedroom, not bothering to respond to her.

Sally had just finished showering, her hair still wet. Those blue eyes of hers looked extremely innocent. "What's wrong? Baby, why are you ignoring me again?"

Lin Luoxi entered, closed the door, locked it—directly locking Sally outside. The movements were done in one smooth sequence.

Sally stared at the door in a daze, then shouted at the door in her clumsy Chinese: "Lin Luoxi! I'm really going to get angry!"

Lin Luoxi: "Go run away from home then!"

Sally: "...I won't!"

Lin Luoxi: "Then what do you want to do?"

Sally: "Open the door!"

Lin Luoxi: "...I won't either."

The two faced off with a door between them.

Sally asked: "What did I do wrong?"

Lin Luoxi: "You talk too much."

Sally: "..."

Lin Luoxi sat in the room, still searching for pregnancy-related information on her phone. Based on Xu Qingzhu's condition these past few days, she could roughly determine that it was indeed pregnancy.

But there seemed to be some problem between her and Liang Shi.

As a friend, there really wasn't much she could help with.

Lin Luoxi had no intention of overstepping to ask Liang Shi. She only sent a message to Xu Qingzhu after closing her search: 【Rest well. If you have time, go to the hospital for a checkup. I asked my friend, and she said you might be pregnant.】

Lin Luoxi: 【If you want, I can pretend I don't know about this.】

Lin Luoxi: 【Pat pat.jpg. Just let me know if you need anything.】

Lin Luoxi: 【I won't tell Sally either.】

After sending the messages, she cleared the chat history.

Only then did she open the door for Sally, who was anxiously hopping at the doorway. Sally immediately slipped into the room. "Are you seeing someone behind my back?"

Lin Luoxi: "..."

"Yes." Lin Luoxi rolled her eyes. "Let me count how many."

She counted on her fingers. "Only six. Is that a lot?"

Sally: "..."

Sally walked forward and wrapped one arm around her slender waist, saying through gritted teeth: "Are you trying to make me angry again?"

"What else?" Lin Luoxi wasn't afraid of her at all. "This is the first time I've seen someone so eager to create rivals for themselves."

Sally leaned in and bit her lip, biting hard enough that Lin Luoxi felt pain. She slapped Sally on the back. "That hurts."

Sally looked aggrieved: "Who told you to make me angry?"

"Who told you to act like an idiot?" Lin Luoxi said.

Sally: "..."

Sally pressed Lin Luoxi against the door, pinning her hands behind her back.

The long, passionate kiss made the entire room feel romantic.

When the kiss ended, Sally and Lin Luoxi each rested on the other's shoulder, catching their breath.

Lin Luoxi suddenly felt her finger slip into something cold. She frowned: "What are you doing?"

Sally lifted her hand, spreading her own fingers to interlock with hers, their ten fingers interlaced.

Her gaze was sincere as she spoke in Mandarin that she must have practiced countless times to barely manage to pronounce correctly: "Lin Luoxi, let's get married."

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Xu Qingzhu seemed to have slept for a very long time. She didn't even notice when the nurse came in to remove the IV needle.

When she woke up, it was already the next morning, with the sun slowly rising.

The room was warm with heating.

If one didn't go outside, they would probably think it was a beautiful sunny day.

Xu Qingzhu subconsciously raised her arm to shield her eyes, then felt her forearm was somewhat numb. Only after her eyes adjusted did she look and find that there was already a small patch of bruising.

Her skin was sensitive, and any carelessness during IV infusions would cause this. It would take a few days to fade.

When she woke up, the doctor and nurse came in.

Seeing that she was about to move, the nurse immediately came forward and held her down: "You shouldn't be moving yet. Just rest. By the way, the bruise on your arm is because you moved your arm too much after you fell asleep last night, causing the needle to shift a bit. But it's nothing serious."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Okay."

The doctor came forward and asked her: "Did you sleep well last night?"

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu said. "Quite well."

At least she felt much more comfortable after a good night's sleep.

Although she hadn't been having nightmares these past few days, she always couldn't fall asleep.

At night, lying on that bed, she would think of Liang Shi. She had to hug Liang Shi's pillow to sleep. Often when she woke up, the pillow was soaked. At first, she thought there was a leak in the house, but then she remembered it was the tenth floor with many more apartments above—how could that be possible?

Only when she wiped her face did she realize it was all her own tears.

Before, she was someone who didn't even bother much with eye makeup. Now, when doing makeup, the most time-consuming part was her eye makeup.

Every time after sleeping, it felt like a huge stone was pressing on her heart, the pain almost making it impossible to breathe.

"I added some sedatives to your medication." The doctor said. "The foundation of good rest is good sleep, and eating comes second. You need to ensure three meals a day."

Xu Qingzhu nodded to show she understood.

After the doctor checked her heartbeat and temperature, she stood there and asked hesitantly: "I don't mean to offend, but where is your family? Even if your partner isn't here, it would be better to have a family member or friend to keep you company. You still need to stay in the hospital for another week..."

"Ah..." Xu Qingzhu hesitated. "I'll find someone. Thank you for your concern."

The doctor nodded: "It's best to find someone you trust, preferably someone with an optimistic personality. Your emotions are still somewhat suppressed right now."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together lightly and thanked her.

After they all left, Xu Qingzhu called her assistant and asked her to buy some new clothes and daily necessities to bring over.

She didn't ask her assistant to go back to her and Liang Shi's home.

That was still private territory that couldn't be violated, as far as she was concerned.

Life in the hospital didn't stop. She still needed to handle company matters, converting all offline meetings to online ones. She occasionally went downstairs for walks and forced herself to eat every day, but she threw up almost as much as she ate.

Looking back on it later, it seemed like a very difficult period.

She was like a puppet on strings. Aside from barely mustering up energy when working, she was always in a daze the rest of the time.

Occasionally she would see the little one in her dreams, and she would also see Liang Shi. Every time she woke up, it felt like waking from a fleeting dream.¹

Waking to reality was cold and quiet—so quiet that she could only hear the sound of her own heartbeat and the constant ticking of the clock on the wall.

She didn't know what was keeping her going.

Countless times she opened her phone wanting to contact Liang Shi, but suppressed the stirring in her heart, telling herself not to disturb her.

She must have things to do.

So she should be obedient.

Countless times she comforted herself with such words, yet every time she cried herself awake from dreams. After crying, she would feel that this wasn't good for the little one in her belly, so she would touch her stomach and tell the little one stories, comforting her.

She didn't know if those words were to comfort the baby or herself.

Xu Qingzhu would say to her: "Mommy loves us. She just has something to do temporarily."

"Mommy will come back."

"Mommy isn't that kind of person."

"..."

Muttering to herself, rambling on, and then falling asleep again in a haze.

Until the final checkup, the doctor reminded her of some things and told her not to let her guard down after going home. The most crucial thing was to maintain a good mood.

On the day she was discharged from the hospital after her checkup, she also received good news. After discussing with Lu Jiayi, they decided to jointly acquire Huayi Media.

This company's upper management had previously gone through a reshuffling, replaced by a batch of parasites, and the upper management was on the verge of falling apart.

Su Zhe was close with the company's founder, and the other party wanted Su Zhe to acquire it, but Su Zhe couldn't spare the energy right now.

In this era of pan-entertainment, having a film and television company under one's wing could not only make money but also bring a lot of other social influence.

So after establishing the cooperation with Lu Jiayi, Xu Qingzhu and Lu Jiayi quickly finalized the plan to acquire Huayi Media.

During Xu Qingzhu's hospitalization, Lu Jiayi had been busy running around for this matter.

She had even come to visit her once and expressed surprise: "Your wife isn't here?"

"She's busy." Still the same formulaic answer.

Lu Jiayi had frowned slightly at the time, but since it was her family matter, she didn't say anything.

And that day, when she was about to leave, Xu Qingzhu hesitated before asking: "Miss Lu, have you ever had a very strange dream?"

Lu Jiayi was puzzled: "What?"

"I dreamed about marrying you." Xu Qingzhu said honestly. "The scene was especially vivid, completely unlike a dream."

Afraid that Lu Jiayi would misunderstand, Xu Qingzhu immediately added: "I'm not expressing interest in you or trying to get closer to you. I'm purely asking... have you ever had a similar dream?"

The last word, Xu Qingzhu said very softly.

Almost breathed out.

After pausing for a few seconds, Lu Jiayi also nodded sincerely: "Yes."

"You've had it too?" Xu Qingzhu was surprised. "Where was it?"

Lu Jiayi looked at her and answered after a moment: "An island."

At the same time, Xu Qingzhu also voiced her question: "An island?"

Their voices overlapped in that instant.

Then they looked at each other in disbelief.

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1. The phrase "黄粱一梦" (huáng liáng yī mèng) literally means "a dream of yellow millet." It comes from an ancient Chinese story where a man falls asleep while waiting for millet to cook and dreams an entire lifetime of success and failure, only to wake and find the millet still cooking. It refers to an illusion of grandeur or a dream that seems real but is fleeting and empty. ⇐

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Lu Jiayi tapped her forehead: "I'm sorry. I shouldn't have had such a dream that offends you. Psychology says dreams are a person's subconscious, but I really have no intention of destroying your family. Absolutely none. I also know that you and your wife are in love with each other, so I would never have thoughts of interfering. Admittedly, you're very outstanding, very suitable as my business partner, and you also match my requirements for a significant other. But I've never had any inappropriate thoughts about you."

She rapidly said a long string of words, sincerely explaining this matter to Xu Qingzhu.

After listening, Xu Qingzhu had no reaction and just nodded woodenly: "I know."

Two people having the same dream—it was as if something in the universe was guiding them to do this.

And Liang Shi had said—the person you should be with isn't me.

So, was the person she should be with Lu Jiayi?

If Liang Shi hadn't become a different person back then, she and Liang Shi would probably be divorced by now.

If she had returned to being single and met Lu Jiayi, she probably would have become Lu Jiayi's ideal marriage partner.

Someone like Lu Jiayi wouldn't mind that her partner had been married before.

Because Lu Jiayi was someone with a strong competitive drive. She prioritized her career over family and marriage, and had a strong sense of responsibility. Marrying someone like that actually matched Xu Qingzhu's previous expectations.

They were truly incomparably compatible in some aspects.

They both liked obscure books, liked the same poet, and even when working on proposals, whenever one made a point, the other could perfectly supplement it.

So collaborating with Lu Jiayi was a very comfortable thing—so comfortable it was like finding another version of herself.

Living a lifetime with such a person would be very comfortable.

No need to doubt the other person like this, no need to compromise for the other person's feelings, no need to argue with each other.

Because both Lu Jiayi and she valued efficiency. When they had a disagreement about something before, Lu Jiayi sat down with her to discuss it rationally, even listing out three options A, B, and C to resolve it. And she did the same.

With such efficiency, who would argue?

As for cold wars, they simply wouldn't exist.

Work was already busy enough every day—how could there be cold wars?

Not talking when the two of them were together was normal, because they could solve problems effectively.

If there was no Liang Shi... she wouldn't reject someone like Lu Jiayi from entering her life.

But... she had fallen in love with Liang Shi.

She wanted to cling to her older sister.

She wanted to hear Liang Shi call her a "spoiled little princess," wanted to kiss her lips.

Xu Qingzhu sat there in a daze for a long time, until Lu Jiayi's voice pulled her back to reality. "Why are you suddenly asking about this?"

Xu Qingzhu lowered her gaze and smiled bitterly. "Just asking casually."

Lu Jiayi: "Oh..."

After that, Lu Jiayi left. Xu Qingzhu sat there thinking about the logic of all this. Halfway through her thoughts, she actually yawned—something that had never happened before.

Then she realized it was the little one who needed rest.

So she lay in bed and slept.

But halfway through her sleep, she was suddenly startled awake by the sound of wind outside. The biting winter wind was blowing wildly.

Frightened, she opened her phone and subconsciously called Liang Shi.

Soon, the call was answered. Xu Qingzhu said in a choked voice: "Liang Shi, I miss you so much."

There was a pause on the other end. Liang Shi's hoarse voice also carried a hint of tears as she answered: "Baby."

That one word made Xu Qingzhu's tears fall like rain.

Liang Shi said: "Why are you crying again?"

Xu Qingzhu scolded her: "You bad person."

Liang Shi said helplessly: "Don't cry."

Later, Xu Qingzhu thought she had been dreaming again. But when she woke up the next day and checked her phone's call history, she found there was a call record at four in the morning.

It had lasted three minutes.

Xu Qingzhu put away her phone, washed her face in the bathroom, and checked out of the hospital.

Chapter 159-5

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That phone call was also answered by Liang Shi unconsciously. Only after speaking did she realize what she had done. She wanted to hang up but couldn't bring herself to.

In the end, she just listened to Xu Qingzhu cry for two minutes and only hung up after she had fallen asleep.

During the days when Xu Qingzhu was hospitalized, Liang Shi accompanied Gu Yixue to Shen Fenghe's wedding.

That day was just an ordinary day of the year.

No wind, no snow.

The most luxurious hotel in Haizhou City had been booked entirely. Shen Fenghe stood in the middle of the red carpet wearing a wedding dress, remaining unmoved no matter what anyone said.

In the countdown she had set, Gu Chunmian ultimately yielded to her family and appeared on the first floor of the hotel wearing a wedding dress.

At that time, Gu Yixue and Liang Shi were sitting in a car by the roadside, watching the car with consecutive license plate numbers stop at the hotel entrance. Gu Chunmian got out of the car like a proud princess.

Liang Shi was nervous for Gu Yixue. She turned back to look at Gu Yixue in her wedding dress.

Today, Gu Yixue was gorgeous and alluring. With the wedding dress on her, it was her face that complemented the dress, not the dress that complemented her.

Afraid that she would feel bad watching, Liang Shi tentatively asked: "Should we leave?"

Gu Yixue shook her head: "The matter isn't settled yet."

After saying that, she got out of the car and walked to the roadside to light a cigarette.

Someone had spread the news that the second young miss of the Gu family had also appeared outside the hotel wearing a wedding dress.

This attracted many onlookers.

Gu Yixue stood there openly, looking back at them as if they were the ones making fools of themselves.

Just when everyone thought the dust had settled, Gu Chunmian answered a phone call in the middle of the ceremony. Her expression changed dramatically. She lifted her wedding dress and ran outside. When she was stopped by the Gu family's bodyguards, she pulled out a knife from somewhere and pointed it at her own neck. "Let me tell you, even if I die today, I won't marry her!"

Then she turned back to look at Shen Fenghe and said coldly: "Shen Fenghe! If you want, you can marry my corpse."

Shen Fenghe watched coldly from the side, practically having the words "If you die, I'll collect your body" written on her face.

And Gu Chunmian actually pressed the blade in a bit further. "Let me go!"

The elders of both the Gu and Shen families were present. Father Shen's face had already darkened, clearly wanting to call off the marriage, but he was held back by Madam Shen.

Shen Fenghe only looked at Gu Chunmian indifferently and asked: "No regrets?"

Gu Chunmian shouted: "I'd only regret it if I married you! You workaholic!"

Shen Fenghe paused for a moment, then said coldly: "Let her go."

The venue was in an uproar.

Just after Gu Chunmian left, Gu Yixue lifted her wedding dress and slowly walked in, asking only one question: "Are we getting married?"

Shen Fenghe clenched her fists tightly and was silent for a very, very long time.

So long that everyone held their breath waiting for her answer.

Shen Fenghe turned around and looked at the officiant: "Continue the wedding."

No unnecessary words—it even stunned the officiant.

But this officiant had seen his share of situations. He stumbled for a moment before answering: "O... Okay."

Gu Yixue stood beside Shen Fenghe, shoulder to shoulder with her. Looking at her from the side, she could only see the silhouette of Shen Fenghe's profile.

The wedding continued.

It was like an absurd farce.

Yet no one present dared to make a sound. Shen Fenghe and Gu Yixue completed the wedding together.

Liang Shi stood not far away. When Gu Yixue threw the bouquet, she threw it to her.

Liang Shi instinctively tossed it away, and it landed in Shen Hui's arms.

The two looked at each other in dismay. Liang Shi then walked over, apologized to Shen Hui, and took the bouquet back.